BHARATANATYAM — MASTER KNOWLEDGE BASE

1. Introduction

Bharatanatyam is one of the major classical dance traditions of India and is particularly associated with Tamil Nadu and the cultural traditions of South India. It is a highly structured performing art that combines rhythmic movement, music, facial expression, hand gestures, body positions, storytelling, poetry, devotion, and dramatic representation. Bharatanatyam is both a technical dance system and an expressive language through which performers communicate stories, emotions, philosophical ideas, devotional themes, and human experiences. Its identity has developed over a long period through the interaction of ancient performing-arts theory, temple traditions, hereditary artistic communities, royal patronage, musical traditions, literary compositions, and modern institutions.

The dance is characterized by precise footwork, geometric body positions, coordinated movements of the hands and eyes, expressive facial movements, symbolic gestures known as mudras or hastas, and complex rhythmic patterns. A dancer must develop physical strength, flexibility, balance, musical understanding, rhythmic precision, emotional expression, and knowledge of the literature being performed. Traditional performances are generally accompanied by Carnatic music and may include a vocalist, mridangam player, violinist, flautist or veena player, and a nattuvanar who guides the rhythmic structure through nattuvangam and spoken rhythmic syllables.

Bharatanatyam is also closely associated with Lord Shiva as Nataraja, the cosmic dancer. However, the history of Bharatanatyam should not be reduced to a single mythological origin. Its present form is the result of a long historical development involving multiple traditions, texts, teachers, performers, composers, temples, courts, and modern institutions.

2. Traditional Origin of Natya

The traditional origin of Indian performing arts is described through the concept of Natya. According to the traditional account associated with the Natya Shastra, the gods desired an art form that could educate, instruct, entertain, and communicate ideas to people from different sections of society. Lord Brahma is said to have created Natya Veda, sometimes described as the fifth Veda, by drawing elements from the four Vedas. The tradition associates recitation or textual expression with the Rigveda, music with the Samaveda, expressive representation with the Yajurveda, and aesthetic experience or rasa with the Atharvaveda. Brahma then entrusted this knowledge to Bharata Muni, who transmitted and organized the principles of dramatic performance.

The Natya Shastra, traditionally attributed to Bharata Muni, is one of the foundational texts of Indian performing-arts theory. It discusses drama, dance, music, gesture, acting, stagecraft, character representation, emotions, aesthetic experience, and performance. It is important to distinguish between the traditional sacred account of the origin of Natya and the later historical development of Bharatanatyam as a specific South Indian dance tradition. The Natya Shastra provides an important theoretical foundation for Indian dance, but Bharatanatyam as practiced today emerged through a much longer process of regional development and transmission.

3. Lord Shiva and Nataraja

Lord Shiva has a central place in the traditional understanding of Indian dance. In his form as Nataraja, meaning Lord or King of Dance, Shiva is represented performing the cosmic dance. His

dance is associated with the continuous processes of creation, preservation, transformation, destruction, concealment, and liberation.

The dynamic aspect of Shiva's dance is commonly described as Tandava. It represents powerful, energetic, and rhythmic movement and is associated with cosmic activity. The Nataraja image typically shows Shiva dancing within a ring of flames. His damaru, or small drum, is associated with sound and creation; the flame represents transformation and destruction; one hand may be held in abhaya mudra, signifying protection or freedom from fear; and the raised foot is associated with liberation. The figure beneath his foot, Apasmara, is traditionally interpreted as representing ignorance.

The Nataraja tradition is particularly significant in Tamil Nadu. The Chidambaram Nataraja Temple is one of the most important centers associated with Shiva as Nataraja. The Nataraja image has become one of the most recognizable symbols associated with Indian dance and the philosophical idea that the universe is characterized by continuous movement and transformation.

4. Goddess Parvati, Lasya, and the Transmission of Dance

Goddess Parvati is traditionally associated with Lasya, a graceful aspect of dance. Indian dance traditions often discuss Tandava and Lasya as complementary qualities, with Tandava generally representing dynamic and vigorous movement and Lasya emphasizing grace, delicacy, beauty, and expressive movement. These categories should not be treated as rigidly exclusive, because Indian dance traditions contain both energetic and graceful qualities.

An important traditional account describes Shiva teaching Bharata Muni the principles of his dance through Tandu, one of Shiva's attendants, giving rise to the association of Tandava with Shiva and Tandu. The same traditional account states that Parvati taught Lasya to Usha, the daughter of Bana. Usha then taught the dance to women of Dvaraka, after which it was traditionally said to have spread further. This story appears in traditional accounts of the transmission of Lasya and illustrates the cultural belief that dance knowledge passed from divine teachers to human communities through generations.

The Parvati-Usha story is therefore best presented as a traditional cultural account of the transmission of dance rather than as a modern historical claim about the documented origin of Bharatanatyam. Such stories remain important because they explain how Indian traditions understood the relationship between divine knowledge, artistic practice, teachers, and generations of performers.

5. Historical Development in South India

The historical development of Bharatanatyam is closely associated with South India, particularly Tamil Nadu. The dance developed within a wider ecosystem of temple worship, music, poetry, literature, court culture, and hereditary artistic communities. Earlier forms and performance traditions associated with the modern dance are commonly discussed under names such as Sadir or Sadir Attam.

Temples served as important centers of artistic activity. Music and dance were integrated into religious and cultural life, and dancers and musicians were connected with temple institutions. South Indian temples also contain sculptures depicting dancers and dance movements. These visual records demonstrate the importance of dance in the artistic and religious culture of the region.

The relationship between ancient dance theory and modern Bharatanatyam is complex. Texts such as the Natya Shastra provide an important theoretical framework, while later texts and regional traditions contributed additional terminology, techniques, and performance practices. The dance seen on the modern stage should therefore be understood as the result of historical continuity as well as adaptation and reconstruction.

6. Devadasi and Hereditary Artistic Traditions

Women known as devadasis historically performed music and dance in connection with temples. Their traditions were part of a larger hereditary system involving dancers, musicians, teachers, composers, and nattuvanars. These communities played a major role in transmitting repertoire, technique, musical compositions, expressive practices, and performance knowledge across generations.

The history of devadasi traditions should be understood within the social and institutional conditions of their respective periods. The performers were not simply entertainers; they were part of established artistic and ritual systems. At the same time, their social position and the institutions supporting their art changed significantly during the colonial period and the social reform movements of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.

The contributions of hereditary performers remain essential to understanding Bharatanatyam. Modern accounts of the dance should therefore recognize both the later institutional revival of the form and the knowledge preserved by hereditary artists.

7. Temple Architecture and Dance

South Indian temple architecture provides important evidence for the historical relationship between dance, religion, sculpture, and performance. Temples such as those at Chidambaram and Thanjavur contain sculptures associated with dance movements.

The Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur contains sculptures representing dance karanas described in the Natya Shastra. The temple originally provided spaces for numerous representations, and surviving sculptures provide valuable evidence for the study of the historical relationship between textual dance theory and visual representations. The Chidambaram temple is also particularly important because of its association with Nataraja and dance.

The concept of the karana is particularly important. The Natya Shastra describes 108 karanas, which are composite units involving coordinated body movements. Modern scholars and dancers have studied temple sculptures and textual descriptions to understand how these movement concepts may relate to Indian dance traditions. The exact relationship between ancient textual karanas, temple sculptures, and modern performance techniques is a subject of scholarship and interpretation rather than a simple one-to-one historical continuity.

8. The Thanjavur Quartet

The nineteenth century was an important period in the shaping of the repertoire associated with modern Bharatanatyam. Four brothers known collectively as the Thanjavur Quartet — Chinnayya, Ponnayya, Sivanandam, and Vadivelu — were influential musicians, composers, and dance masters associated with the Thanjavur court.

They contributed significantly to the organization and development of the dance repertoire and are strongly associated with the structure known as the Margam. Their compositions and choreographic contributions became important parts of the performance tradition.

The Margam can be understood as a progression through different forms of pure dance, rhythm, expression, and dramatic interpretation. Its structure allowed a performer to demonstrate technical skill while gradually developing expressive and emotional complexity.

9. Nritta, Nritya, and Natya

Bharatanatyam can be understood through three broad categories: Nritta, Nritya, and Natya.

Nritta is pure dance. Its primary purpose is rhythmic and aesthetic rather than the direct communication of a narrative. Nritta emphasizes precise movements, footwork, body positions, patterns, and coordination with rhythm.

Nritya combines dance with expression. The performer uses facial expressions, hand gestures, eye movements, body language, and music to communicate the meaning and emotion of a composition.

Natya involves dramatic representation. It can include the portrayal of characters, situations, stories, and relationships through dance and expressive acting.

These three categories are interconnected rather than completely separate. A single Bharatanatyam performance may move between pure rhythmic passages, expressive storytelling, and dramatic representation.

10. Abhinaya

Abhinaya is one of the most important concepts in Bharatanatyam. It refers broadly to the methods by which meaning and emotion are communicated through performance.

Traditional Indian theory describes four broad forms of abhinaya:

1. **Angika Abhinaya — expression through the body, limbs, gestures, eyes, facial movements, and physical action.**
2. **Vachika Abhinaya — expression through speech, lyrics, music, and vocal elements.**
3. **Aharya Abhinaya — expression through costume, jewellery, makeup, stage appearance, and visual presentation.**
4. **Sattvika Abhinaya — expression of inner emotional states and psychological feeling.**

Through abhinaya, a dancer can communicate an entire story without ordinary spoken dialogue. A single hand gesture may represent an object, person, animal, action, or idea depending on the context. Facial expressions and eye movements help communicate the emotional meaning of the performance.

11. Bhava and Rasa

Bharatanatyam is deeply connected with the Indian aesthetic concepts of Bhava and Rasa.

Bhava refers to an emotional state or feeling represented by the performer. Rasa refers to the aesthetic experience evoked in the audience through artistic presentation.

Classical Indian aesthetic theory discusses different emotional and aesthetic experiences, including love, humour, compassion, anger, heroism, fear, disgust, wonder, and peace. The dancer does not simply imitate an emotion but uses carefully controlled expression, gesture, movement, music, and context to communicate the emotional world of the composition.

This makes Bharatanatyam a sophisticated form of emotional storytelling in which physical technique and psychological expression work together.

12. Adavus and Aramandi

Adavus are fundamental movement units used in Bharatanatyam training. They combine coordinated movements of the feet, legs, arms, hands, body, and head with specific rhythmic patterns. Different schools and teaching traditions may organize and name adavus differently.

The dancer repeatedly practices adavus to develop coordination, balance, rhythm, strength, flexibility, precision, and muscle memory.

One of the most recognizable postures is Aramandi. In this position, the dancer bends the knees outward while keeping the torso controlled and upright. The posture creates the characteristic triangular or geometric visual quality of Bharatanatyam and provides a stable foundation for footwork and movement.

The technical discipline required to maintain Aramandi while performing complicated rhythmic patterns is one of the defining physical challenges of the dance.

13. Mudras and Hastas

Hand gestures are an important part of Bharatanatyam. They are generally referred to as Hastas or Mudras.

Single-hand gestures are commonly described as Asamyuta Hastas, while double-hand gestures are described as Samyuta Hastas. Different gestures can represent objects, people, animals, actions, emotions, natural elements, directions, or abstract ideas.

The meaning of a gesture is determined by context. A particular hand position can communicate different meanings depending on the accompanying movement, facial expression, lyrics, and narrative.

This symbolic vocabulary allows Bharatanatyam to function as a visual language. A dancer can construct a narrative by combining hand gestures with eye movements, facial expressions, body positions, and rhythmic movement.

14. Margam and Performance Structure

A traditional Bharatanatyam recital is often organized according to a repertoire structure known as Margam, meaning a path or progression.

A commonly presented Margam includes:

Alarippu — an introductory rhythmic piece that gradually activates and coordinates the body.

Jatiswaram — a pure dance composition combining rhythmic patterns with melodic structures.

Shabdam — an expressive composition that introduces storytelling and often devotional or descriptive themes.

Varnam — generally the central and most demanding section, combining complex rhythmic passages with extensive abhinaya and requiring considerable stamina and concentration.

Padam — an expressive composition focusing on subtle emotional interpretation and often dealing with devotion, love, longing, or relationships.

Javali — a shorter expressive composition that often deals with themes of love and human relationships.

Tillana — a lively rhythmic composition emphasizing energetic movement, complex footwork, and musical patterns.

Mangalam — a concluding section associated with gratitude, blessing, or respectful closure.

Not every performance follows exactly the same sequence. Modern dancers and choreographers may adapt the repertoire according to the theme, tradition, duration, and artistic purpose of the performance.

15. Carnatic Music and Rhythm

Bharatanatyam is closely associated with Carnatic music. The dancer performs in coordination with melody, rhythm, lyrics, and tala.

Raga provides the melodic framework, while Tala provides the rhythmic cycle. The relationship between the dancer and musicians is extremely precise.

The Nattuvanar traditionally plays an important role by reciting rhythmic syllables and coordinating the dancer with the musical ensemble. The nattuvangam consists of small cymbals used to mark rhythm, while sollukattu refers to spoken rhythmic syllables.

The mridangam is one of the principal percussion instruments accompanying Bharatanatyam. Other instruments may include violin, flute, veena, and vocal music. The dancer's ankle bells, known as Salangai, further emphasize rhythmic footwork.

16. Costume, Jewellery, and Visual Presentation

The Bharatanatyam costume is designed to emphasize the dancer's movements and body positions. Traditional costumes are generally made from silk or silk-like fabrics and include pleated sections that spread out when the dancer assumes Aramandi.

The dancer commonly wears temple-style jewellery, necklaces, earrings, bangles, waist ornaments, head decorations, and flowers in the hair. Ankle bells emphasize rhythmic footwork.

Stage makeup highlights the eyes, eyebrows, lips, and facial features so that expressions can be clearly seen by the audience. The visual appearance of the dancer is therefore not merely decorative; costume and makeup contribute to the communication of movement, character, and expression.

17. Storytelling and Literature

Bharatanatyam has a strong storytelling tradition. Performances may interpret stories and characters from the Ramayana, Mahabharata, Bhagavata Purana, Puranic literature, devotional traditions, Sanskrit works, Tamil literature, Telugu compositions, and Carnatic musical repertoire.

Common subjects include Shiva, Parvati, Krishna, Vishnu, Rama, Sita, Ganesha, and other figures from Indian religious and literary traditions.

However, Bharatanatyam is not restricted to mythology. Dancers and choreographers also use its vocabulary to explore human relationships, nature, social themes, historical events, philosophical ideas, emotional experiences, and contemporary subjects.

A dancer can portray multiple characters in a single composition by changing gestures, facial expressions, posture, movement quality, and direction. This makes Bharatanatyam an extremely versatile storytelling medium.

18. Spiritual and Cultural Significance

Bharatanatyam has historically been associated with devotion and temple culture. Many traditional compositions express Bhakti, or devotion, and portray the relationship between the individual and the divine.

The association with Nataraja connects dance with the philosophical idea of cosmic movement and transformation. Devotional compositions may portray longing for the divine, surrender, praise, or spiritual union.

At the same time, Bharatanatyam is broader than religious performance. It is also a system of music, movement, theatre, poetry, aesthetics, and cultural expression. Its significance comes from its ability to preserve and transmit knowledge across generations.

Through Bharatanatyam, audiences encounter Indian literature, languages, musical traditions, philosophical ideas, visual symbolism, and historical performance practices.

19. Colonial Period and Transformation

During the colonial period, traditional temple and hereditary dance systems underwent major social and institutional changes. Anti-nautch campaigns, social reform movements, changing attitudes toward temple performance, and the decline of traditional patronage affected the status and practice of hereditary dance communities.

The dance tradition was subsequently transformed as it entered new social spaces such as public theatres, cultural institutions, schools, and academies.

This period should not be described simply as the disappearance of Bharatanatyam followed by its invention in the twentieth century. Rather, modern Bharatanatyam emerged through a complicated process involving existing hereditary traditions, reform movements, reinterpretation, new audiences, institutional teaching, and cultural revival.

20. Revival and Modernization

The twentieth century was crucial to the establishment of Bharatanatyam as a widely recognized classical stage tradition.

E. Krishna Iyer was an important advocate for the recognition and revival of South Indian dance. Rukmini Devi Arundale played a major role in establishing institutional training through Kalakshetra in Chennai, founded in 1936.

At the same time, T. Balasaraswati became one of the most important representatives of the hereditary performance tradition and was internationally recognized for her mastery of Bharatanatyam, especially its expressive dimensions.

The modern history of Bharatanatyam therefore includes both institutional revival and the continuing contributions of hereditary performers and lineages. These different streams contributed to the form's survival, expansion, documentation, and international recognition. The Sangeet Natak Akademi's records also document major Bharatanatyam artists and teachers, including Rukmini Devi Arundale and T. Balasaraswati.

21. Guru-Shishya Tradition and Training

Bharatanatyam traditionally developed through the Guru-Shishya system. Students learned directly from teachers through observation, repetition, correction, memorization, and long-term practice.

Training generally begins with basic postures, hand positions, eye movements, adavus, rhythmic exercises, and simple compositions. As the student progresses, increasingly complex rhythmic and expressive pieces are introduced.

The student must develop physical conditioning, rhythm, coordination, musical understanding, facial expression, memory, stage presence, and knowledge of the meaning of compositions.

Learning Bharatanatyam is therefore not limited to memorizing choreography. Traditional training involves understanding the relationship between movement, music, literature, rhythm, emotion, and meaning.

22. Arangetram

Arangetram is traditionally a major milestone in the training of a Bharatanatyam student. The term is generally understood as the student's first major public performance or formal stage debut after substantial training.

An Arangetram typically presents a substantial repertoire and demonstrates the student's technical ability, rhythmic understanding, expressive skill, and stage readiness.

It does not mean that the dancer has completed learning Bharatanatyam. Classical dance training can continue throughout the performer's life, and advanced dancers continue developing technique, interpretation, choreography, and artistic identity.

23. Important Personalities

Several individuals have played significant roles in the modern history and development of Bharatanatyam.

Bharata Muni is traditionally associated with the Natya Shastra and the theoretical foundations of Indian performing arts.

Tandu is associated in traditional accounts with the transmission of Shiva's dance and the concept of Tandava.

Rukmini Devi Arundale was instrumental in establishing institutional training and popularizing Bharatanatyam through Kalakshetra.

T. Balasaraswati was a major representative of the hereditary performance tradition and was renowned for her mastery of abhinaya.

E. Krishna Iyer was an important advocate for the recognition and revival of South Indian dance.

The Thanjavur Quartet — Chinnayya, Ponnayya, Sivanandam, and Vadivelu — played a major role in shaping the traditional repertoire and Margam structure.

Later generations of dancers, teachers, scholars, composers, and choreographers continued to expand the tradition and introduce Bharatanatyam to new audiences.

24. Bharatanatyam and the 108 Karanas

The Natya Shastra describes 108 Karanas, which are composite movement units involving coordinated positions and movements of different parts of the body.

Dance sculptures associated with Karanas can be found in several South Indian temples. Thanjavur, Chidambaram, Kumbakonam, Tiruvannamalai, and other temple sites have been important in scholarly studies of these movement representations.

Modern scholars and dancers have undertaken extensive research into the relationship between the textual descriptions, temple sculptures, and living dance traditions. Padma Subrahmanyam is particularly associated with research and practical reconstruction of the 108 Karanas.

The Karanas demonstrate the relationship between Indian dance theory, architecture, sculpture, textual knowledge, and performance practice.

25. Bharatanatyam as a Living Art

Bharatanatyam is not a frozen historical artifact. It continues to evolve.

Traditional dancers continue to perform established compositions and repertoire, while contemporary choreographers use Bharatanatyam techniques to explore subjects beyond traditional devotional narratives.

Modern productions may address environmental concerns, women's experiences, social issues, historical subjects, identity, philosophy, intercultural exchange, and contemporary life.

Some artists experiment with new music, theatre, multimedia, lighting, projection, and collaborations with other dance forms. Other artists concentrate on preserving traditional schools, compositions, and performance practices.

Both preservation and innovation are part of the continuing history of Bharatanatyam.

26. Global Presence

Bharatanatyam is now performed not only throughout India but also in many countries through cultural institutions, universities, Indian diaspora communities, dance schools, festivals, and independent artists.

Digital platforms have further expanded access to performances and educational material. Students can now observe dancers from different schools and traditions, study historical recordings, access lectures and demonstrations, and connect with teachers across geographical boundaries.

International performance has transformed Bharatanatyam into an important form of cultural representation while also creating new questions about adaptation, authenticity, interpretation, and cultural context.

27. Major Concepts and Vocabulary

Important Bharatanatyam and Indian classical dance terms include:

Bharatanatyam — a major classical dance tradition associated with Tamil Nadu.

Natya — dramatic and performing expression.

Natya Shastra — ancient Indian treatise traditionally attributed to Bharata Muni.

Nritta — pure rhythmic dance.

Nritya — expressive dance combining movement and meaning.

Natya — dramatic representation.

Abhinaya — expressive communication.

Bhava — emotional state represented through performance.

Rasa — aesthetic experience evoked in the audience.

Mudra/Hasta — symbolic hand gesture.

Adavu — fundamental movement unit used in Bharatanatyam training.

Aramandi — characteristic half-sitting posture.

Tala — rhythmic cycle.

Raga — melodic framework.

Margam — traditional progression of Bharatanatyam repertoire.

Nattuvanar — person traditionally responsible for conducting or guiding the rhythmic aspects of a performance.

Nattuvangam — rhythmic cymbal accompaniment and the practice of marking rhythm.

Sollukattu — spoken rhythmic syllables.

Salangai — ankle bells worn by the dancer.

Tandava — dynamic dance traditionally associated with Shiva.

Lasya — graceful dance traditionally associated with Parvati.

Nataraja — Shiva as Lord of Dance.

Karana — composite movement unit described in the Natya Shastra.

Arangetram — formal debut or major public performance marking a stage in a dancer's training.

28. Why Bharatanatyam Is Significant

Bharatanatyam is significant because it brings together multiple dimensions of Indian culture within a single artistic system. It preserves movement vocabulary, musical traditions, literature, poetry, mythology, philosophy, storytelling, costume traditions, and performance knowledge.

It also demonstrates how artistic knowledge can be transmitted across generations. Teachers pass techniques to students, musicians accompany dancers, compositions preserve literary and musical traditions, and performances reinterpret older material for new audiences.

Its significance is therefore historical, artistic, cultural, educational, musical, literary, and spiritual.

29. What Makes Bharatanatyam Special

The speciality of Bharatanatyam lies in the combination of precision and expression.

A dancer can perform extremely complex rhythmic sequences while maintaining controlled posture and balance. The same dancer can then shift into subtle facial expression and communicate an emotional or narrative passage.

The dance uses the entire body as a communication system. Feet communicate rhythm, hands communicate symbolic meaning, eyes direct attention, facial expressions communicate emotion, and the body creates shapes and movement patterns.

Music determines rhythm and mood, poetry supplies narrative meaning, costume and jewellery create visual identity, and stage performance brings all these elements together.

This combination makes Bharatanatyam simultaneously a dance, a musical performance, a dramatic art, a storytelling system, and a cultural tradition.

30. Overall Understanding

Bharatanatyam should be understood as both an ancient cultural tradition and a living contemporary art form. Its traditional knowledge connects it with the Natya Shastra, Bharata Muni, Brahma's creation of Natya, Shiva as Nataraja, Tandava, Parvati's Lasya, and the traditional transmission of dance through figures such as Usha. Its historical development connects it with Tamil Nadu, South Indian temples, hereditary performers, devadasi traditions, nattuvanars, royal courts, musicians, composers, and the Thanjavur tradition.

Its modern history includes colonial-era social changes, reform movements, revival, institutionalization, artists such as E. Krishna Iyer, Rukmini Devi Arundale, and T. Balasaraswati, and the continuing work of teachers and performers.

Its technique includes Nritta, Nritya, Natya, Abhinaya, Bhava, Rasa, Mudras, Adavus, Aramandi, Tala, Raga, Margam, and Karana. Its performances use Carnatic music, rhythmic footwork, ankle bells, traditional costumes, jewellery, facial expression, and storytelling.

Its cultural importance lies in its ability to carry knowledge across generations while remaining open to reinterpretation. Bharatanatyam therefore represents both continuity and change: it preserves ancient theories and cultural memories while allowing contemporary artists to create new works and communicate new ideas.

For these reasons, Bharatanatyam can be understood not simply as a dance performed on a stage, but as a comprehensive Indian artistic tradition in which movement, music, literature, emotion, philosophy, history, spirituality, and storytelling are brought together through disciplined human performance.